

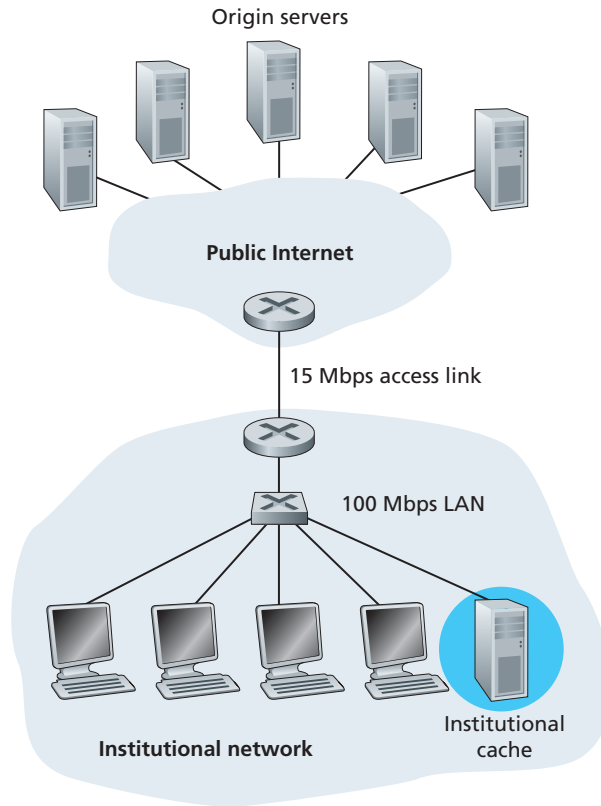


Figure 2.13 ♦ Adding a cache to the institutional network

and install a Web cache. But this cost is low—many caches use public-domain software that runs on inexpensive PCs.

Through the use of **Content Distribution Networks (CDNs)**, Web caches are increasingly playing an important role in the Internet. A CDN company installs many geographically distributed caches throughout the Internet, thereby localizing much of the traffic. There are shared CDNs (such as Akamai and Limelight) and dedicated CDNs (such as Google and Microsoft). We will discuss CDNs in more detail in Chapter 7.

2.2.6 The Conditional GET

Although caching can reduce user-perceived response times, it introduces a new problem—the copy of an object residing in the cache may be stale. In other words, the object housed in the Web server may have been modified since the copy was cached at the client. Fortunately, HTTP has a mechanism that allows a cache to verify that its objects are up to date. This mechanism is called the **conditional GET**. An HTTP

request message is a so-called conditional GET message if (1) the request message uses the GET method and (2) the request message includes an **If-Modified-Since:** header line.

To illustrate how the conditional GET operates, let's walk through an example. First, on the behalf of a requesting browser, a proxy cache sends a request message to a Web server:

```
GET /fruit/kiwi.gif HTTP/1.1
Host: www.exotiquecuisine.com
```

Second, the Web server sends a response message with the requested object to the cache:

```
HTTP/1.1 200 OK
Date: Sat, 8 Oct 2011 15:39:29
Server: Apache/1.3.0 (Unix)
Last-Modified: Wed, 7 Sep 2011 09:23:24
Content-Type: image/gif
```

```
(data data data data data ...)
```

The cache forwards the object to the requesting browser but also caches the object locally. Importantly, the cache also stores the last-modified date along with the object. Third, one week later, another browser requests the same object via the cache, and the object is still in the cache. Since this object may have been modified at the Web server in the past week, the cache performs an up-to-date check by issuing a conditional GET. Specifically, the cache sends:

```
GET /fruit/kiwi.gif HTTP/1.1
Host: www.exotiquecuisine.com
If-modified-since: Wed, 7 Sep 2011 09:23:24
```

Note that the value of the **If-modified-since:** header line is exactly equal to the value of the **Last-Modified:** header line that was sent by the server one week ago. This conditional GET is telling the server to send the object only if the object has been modified since the specified date. Suppose the object has not been modified since 7 Sep 2011 09:23:24. Then, fourth, the Web server sends a response message to the cache:

```
HTTP/1.1 304 Not Modified
Date: Sat, 15 Oct 2011 15:39:29
Server: Apache/1.3.0 (Unix)
```

```
(empty entity body)
```

We see that in response to the conditional GET, the Web server still sends a response message but does not include the requested object in the response message. Including the requested object would only waste bandwidth and increase user-perceived response time, particularly if the object is large. Note that this last response message has **304 Not Modified** in the status line, which tells the cache that it can go ahead and forward its (the proxy cache's) cached copy of the object to the requesting browser.

This ends our discussion of HTTP, the first Internet protocol (an application-layer protocol) that we've studied in detail. We've seen the format of HTTP messages and the actions taken by the Web client and server as these messages are sent and received. We've also studied a bit of the Web's application infrastructure, including caches, cookies, and back-end databases, all of which are tied in some way to the HTTP protocol.

2.3 File Transfer: FTP

In a typical FTP session, the user is sitting in front of one host (the local host) and wants to transfer files to or from a remote host. In order for the user to access the remote account, the user must provide a user identification and a password. After providing this authorization information, the user can transfer files from the local file system to the remote file system and vice versa. As shown in Figure 2.14, the user interacts with FTP through an FTP user agent. The user first provides the hostname of the remote host, causing the FTP client process in the local host to establish a TCP connection with the FTP server process in the remote host. The user then provides the user identification and password, which are sent over the TCP connection as part of FTP commands. Once the server has authorized the user, the user copies one or more files stored in the local file system into the remote file system (or vice versa).

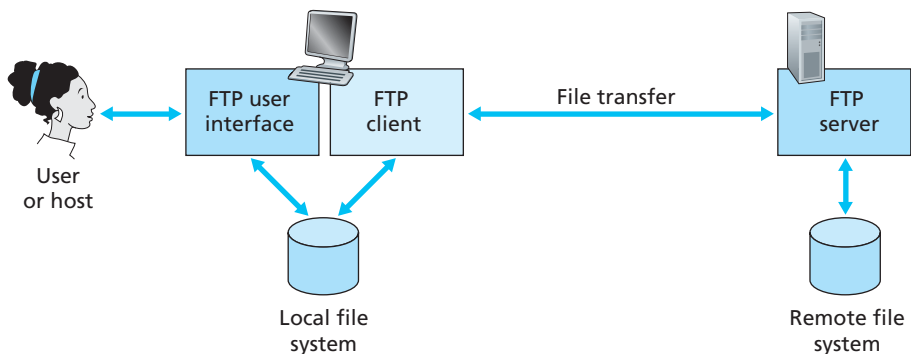


Figure 2.14 ♦ FTP moves files between local and remote file systems